

Daily Economic Briefing

Thursday, 20 August 2026 | Edition 4 | Prepared for Alex | Window: Sun 16 Aug 20:15 ET → Thu 20 Aug approx. 05:30 ET

Assumption / gap disclosure (unattended run): No edition ran on Tue 18 or Wed 19 Aug — the scheduled trigger did not fire on its normal weekday cadence between Mon 17 Aug and this run (Thu 20 Aug, approx. 09:22 UTC / 05:22 ET, well after the intended 07:00 ICT slot). This is a catch-up edition covering all three missed sessions (Mon 17, Tue 18, Wed 19 Aug). Monday and Tuesday get condensed, catch-up-depth treatment; Wednesday (the most recent close) gets normal full-depth treatment. Alex should check whether the scheduled task needs attention — flagged separately outside this document.

- 60-second read
- 1. **Catch-up window, net muted.** S&P 500 fell Mon (−0.5%) and Tue (−0.7%) then recovered Wed (+0.2%, to 7,707.98)¹⁻³ — still off last Thursday's record close, small-caps whipsawed hardest (Russell 2000 −0.4%, −1.3%, +0.5%).
 - 2. **Moderna's melanoma data was the single biggest event of the window.** MRNA closed **+176.97% at \$174.38** Wed on positive Phase 3 data pairing its individualized cancer vaccine with Merck's Keytruda; Merck itself added roughly 12%⁴ — a genuine biotech-modality validation, not a rumor-driven spike.
 - 3. **AI/chip complex sold off hard Tuesday, stabilized Wednesday.** Nasdaq −1.3% and the semiconductor index −4.96% Tue on valuation pushback and AI-financing scrutiny (Broadcom −3.3% on a VMware exploit plus sell-side concern over its AI-financing backstop exposure; Micron −7.0%, Baidu −12.7%, CoreWeave −12.1%)⁵⁻⁹; enterprise SaaS (Monday.com, Salesforce, ServiceNow) diverged higher the same day.
 - 4. **FOMC July minutes leaned hawkish but didn't move stocks.** 9–3 hold, three regional presidents dissented for a hike; minutes warned delay could force a steeper tightening path later^{10,11}. Equities shrugged it off — helped by a same-day Treasury announcement doubling long-bond buybacks, which pulled the 10-year back from a 20-month high near 4.75% toward 4.65%^{12,13}. September-hike odds sit roughly 30–35% on secondary CME tracking^{14,15}.
 - 5. **Retail earnings mixed; oil re-rated higher on Iran risk.** Home Depot and Analog Devices beat and held/raised guidance; Target and TJX beat headline numbers but guided cautiously and sold off; Lowe's cut guidance yet still closed higher; Estee Lauder jumped roughly 13% on a strong beat-and-raise¹⁶⁻²². WTI settled \$85.83 (+1.1%) and Brent \$91.62 (+0.7%) Wednesday, both the highest since 24 July, after the UAE suspended all trade and financial ties with Iran^{23,24}.

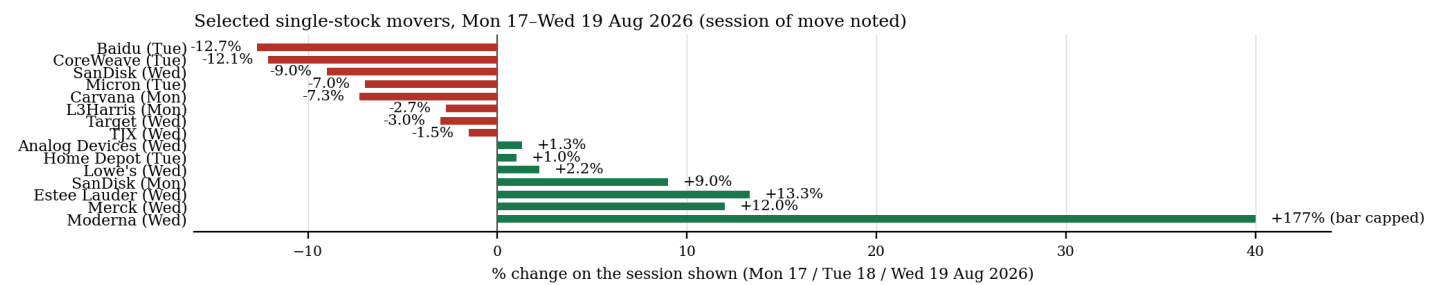
1 • Market recap

Three-session catch-up table — AP wire closes, cross-checked against Yahoo Finance market wraps; used as authoritative over same-day snapshots that disagreed by more than rounding.¹⁻³

Session	S&P 500	Dow	Nasdaq Comp.	Russell 2000	VIX	10Y UST*
Mon 17 Aug	7,745.06 −0.5%	53,459.78 −0.5%	26,644.91 −0.3%	3,057.54 −0.4%	15.19	approx. 4.68%
Tue 18 Aug	7,691.76 −0.7%	53,343.40 −0.2%	26,289.71 −1.3%	3,017.89 −1.3%	15.84	approx. 4.72–4.75%
Wed 19 Aug	7,707.98 +0.2%	53,463.05 +0.2%	26,331.09 +0.2%	3,032.94 +0.5%	15.72	approx. 4.65–4.68%

*Secondary market levels — official Treasury par-yield curve/H.15 lag a business day; direction and rough range shown, not an exact print.¹³

Wednesday snapped a three-session losing streak and was the first gain since last Thursday's record close. Healthcare and cyclicals led Wednesday; technology lagged on continued chip-sector caution.^{3,25} A confirmed closing 11-sector GICS table was not obtainable for any of the three sessions (Annex A); Monday/Tuesday sector reads below use State Street SPDR ETF proxies.



2 • Equities and earnings

Earnings reported this window (all beat-or-miss vs. consensus where stated)				
Name	Date	Result	Guidance	Reaction
Home Depot (HD)	Tue AM	Rev \$47.9B +5.7% y/y; adj. EPS \$4.92 vs \$4.73 est.	FY reaffirmed: sales +2.5–4.5%, EPS flat-to-+4%	+1.0%
Target (TGT)	Wed AM	Sales \$26.5B +5.3%; comp +3.8%; EPS \$4.11 incl. \$994M tariff-refund benefit	Raised: sales +approx.5%, EPS \$9.90–10.90	−3.0%
TJX Cos.	Wed AM	Sales \$15.2B +5%; adj. EPS \$1.22 +11% (ex tariff refund); Marmaxx comp only +1%	Q3 EPS guide \$1.30–1.32 vs \$1.35 est. — light	−1.5%

Estee Lauder (EL)	Wed AM	Rev \$3.63B vs \$3.54B est.; adj. EPS \$0.39 vs \$0.32 est.	FY27: organic sales +3–5%, EPS \$3.10–3.35	approx.+13%
Lowe's (LOW)	Wed AM	Sales approx.\$26.1B; comp +0.2% (5th straight positive); DIY soft, Pro strong	Cut to low end: sales approx.\$92B, EPS approx.\$12.25	+2.0–2.2%
Analog Devices (ADI)	Wed	Rev \$4.02B +40% y/y; adj. EPS \$3.45 +68%, broad Data Center/Industrial demand	Q4: rev \$4.3B ±\$100M, adj. EPS \$3.86 ±\$0.15	+1.3%

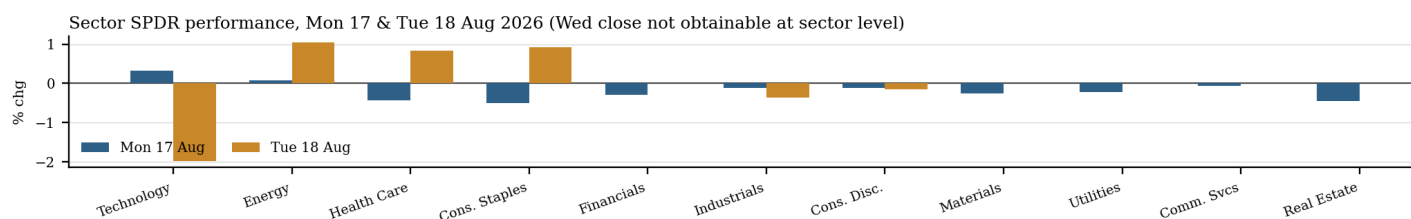
Lowe's close corroborated against two independent price-history sources after an initial three-way conflict across news aggregators (Annex A).^{21,22} Target and TJX's headline EPS both benefited from one-time tariff-refund items; underlying growth was more modest than the headline suggests.^{17,18}

Monday 17 Aug — catch-up

Indices modestly lower in a wait-and-see session ahead of retail earnings; rising oil and a firmer 10-year (+5bp to approx.4.68%) weighed.^{1,26} **L3Harris Technologies** ousted CEO Christopher Kubasik effective immediately over a board-identified Code of Conduct violation unrelated to financials or controls; President Sam Mehta (previously running >80% of revenue via Space & Mission Systems and Communications & Spectrum Dominance) became CEO; shares fell approx.2.7–4%; Kubasik forfeited approx.\$45M in unvested awards but retains approx.\$80M in stock/options.^{27–29} **SanDisk** +9.0% on continued memory-chip strength; **Carvana** –7.3%, the S&P's largest single-day decliner.¹ Follow-through from Berkshire Hathaway's Friday 13F (added approx.\$17B to Alphabet, now a top-holding stake, and expanded homebuilder positions) was cited as a contributing theme for the session.^{30,31}

Tuesday 18 Aug — catch-up: the AI/chip selloff

Third straight decline off last Thursday's record; AP and Reuters wraps both centered the story on Nvidia, Micron and Broadcom as the heaviest drags amid valuation criticism.^{2,32} Semiconductor index (SOXX) –4.96%; **Teradyne** –8.8%, **ARM** –6.7%, **Intel** –6.6%.⁵ **Micron** –7.0% to \$940.76.⁶ **Broadcom** –3.3%, pressured by an actively-exploited VMware vCenter vulnerability plus renewed scrutiny of its AI-customer financing "backstop" exposure and a rich 65.5x trailing P/E versus a 45.9x five-year median.⁷ **Baidu** –12.7% on a Q2 revenue miss (\$4.62B vs \$4.65B est.) as core ad revenue fell 19% y/y for a fourth straight quarter, partly offset by AI Cloud revenue +50% y/y.⁸ **CoreWeave** –12.1% on rising-yield pressure on its debt-financed capex model.⁸ Enterprise SaaS diverged positively the same day — **Monday.com** +5.7% on an earnings beat, Salesforce +2.7%, ServiceNow +1.5%.⁸ Sector SPDRs: Energy +1.05%, Consumer Staples +0.93%, Health Care +0.84% led; Technology –1.99% lagged.³³



Wednesday 19 Aug — most recent close

S&P/Dow/Nasdaq all firmer, first gain in four sessions, on Treasury's buyback expansion and strong retail prints; hawkish FOMC minutes (Section 3) did not derail the advance.³ The session's dominant single-stock story: **Moderna and Merck** announced positive Phase 3 melanoma data pairing Moderna's individualized neoantigen therapy intismeran autogene with Merck's Keytruda — the first successful readout for this "INT" modality, meaningfully longer recurrence/metastasis-free survival than Keytruda alone. MRNA closed **+176.97% at \$174.38** (verified against two independently timestamped post-close reports; earlier same-day snapshots citing 90–160% were intraday, taken before the stock's late extension); Bloomberg estimated the move cost short-sellers roughly \$5.5B.^{4,34} Merck added approx.12%.⁴ Elsewhere: **SanDisk** reversed hard, –9% after Monday's +9% on renewed chip-sector caution; **Viking Holdings** –4% on European river-cruise water-level concerns.²⁵

3 • Macro, policy and rates

FOMC July minutes (released Wed 2pm ET): held 3.50–3.75%, 9–3, with Cleveland's Hammack, Minneapolis's Kashkari and Dallas's Logan dissenting for a 25bp hike. Minutes said "policy tightening would likely be necessary if inflation did not decline" and warned delay risked a "steeper and potentially more costly" tightening path later; inflation risks characterized as tilted to the upside, with AI-driven data-center and infrastructure spending flagged as a new inflationary channel alongside tariff pass-through.^{10,11} No Fed speakers appeared Mon–Wed per the Board's official calendar — notable ahead of this week's Jackson Hole run-up.³⁵ September-hike odds run roughly 30–35% on secondary CME tracking (approx.65–70% hold) — official FedWatch page not directly fetchable, so treat as an aggregated range, not a live pull.^{14,15}

Separately, **Treasury Secretary Bessent** announced doubling the size cap on long-dated (10–30yr) debt buyback operations to at least \$4B; economists called it small relative to the approx.\$30T Treasury market but a symbolic signal. The 10-year eased roughly 10bp on the news even as the minutes leaned hawkish.^{12,13}

Data this window: NAHB Housing Market Index 35 vs 33 est. (Mon)³⁶; Canada CPI +3.0% y/y vs 2.9% est. (Mon)³⁷; housing starts –12.4% m/m to 1.239M SAAR, permits +5% to 1.443M — a starts/permits divergence (Tue)³⁸; import prices –0.4% m/m (largest drop since May 2025), export prices –1.3% m/m (Tue)³⁹; industrial production +0.2% vs +0.3% est. (Tue)⁴⁰. **China's July activity dump** (Mon, Beijing time) missed broadly: industrial production +4.5% y/y vs +4.8% est., retail sales +0.6% vs +1.5% est., YTD fixed-asset investment –6.7% vs –6.0% est., urban unemployment 5.2% vs 5.1% est.⁴¹

Iran/Gulf: Bessent's pledged "unprecedented economic isolation" package against Iran (flagged 14 Aug) remained unrolled through Tuesday, reportedly still weighing sanctions on Chinese refiners/banks handling Iranian trade.⁴² More market-immediate: the **UAE suspended all trade and financial transactions**

with Iran "until further notice" Wednesday after renewed missile activity near its territory — the sharpest regional escalation of the window and the primary driver behind the oil move in Section 4.^{23,24}

4 • Commodities and FX

Oil rallied through the window on Hormuz/Iran risk: Brent approx.\$91.5 Mon, approx.\$91.0 Tue, settling **\$91.62 (+0.7%)** Wed, its highest since 24 July; WTI settled **\$85.83 (+1.1%)** Wed, also a five-week high — both confirmed via explicit settlement-language wire copy after other same-day snapshots disagreed by \$2–3/bbl.^{23,26,43} EIA's weekly report (Wed) showed crude stocks +4.4M bbl vs +0.2M est.⁴⁴ **Natural gas** approx.\$2.78/MMBtu, up from approx.\$2.68 Monday on a Texas heat wave lifting power-sector demand (Houston forecast approx.100°F, 20–23 Aug).⁴⁵ **Gold** choppy: \$4,440 Mon, \$4,387 Tue (10-year yield spike raised bullion's opportunity cost), rebounding toward a two-month high approx.\$4,461–4,480 Wed as yields eased on the Treasury buyback news.^{46–48} **Silver** approx.\$63–66/oz Wed — sources disagreed on both magnitude and direction; reported as a range rather than a single print (Annex A). **Copper** held approx.\$6.60–6.61/lb through the window; the 12 Aug Comex record of \$6.7140 was not broken.⁴⁹ **Platinum** \$1,802.60, –0.4% Wed, +10% on the month.⁵⁰

DXY slipped toward a two-month low early in the window (sub-100) then stabilized approx.99.6–99.7 by Wed.^{26,51} **EUR/USD** 1.1676 Wed, a fresh two-month high, on trimmed Fed-hike bets versus firmer ECB-hike odds.⁵² **USD/JPY** holding just under 160 into Wed, with market wariness building over potential BoJ intervention near that threshold.⁵³ **GBP/USD** 1.3557 (+0.2%) on broad dollar softness; UK CPI printed in line at 2.9% headline / 2.6% core.⁵⁴ **USD/CAD** 1.3810 (–0.6%) after Trump paused a threatened 50% tariff on select Canadian goods for three days following talks with PM Carney.⁵⁵

5 • Derivatives, volatility and positioning

VIX 15.19 Mon (+6.6%, bouncing off Friday's 2026-low close), 15.84 Tue (+4.3%, chip selloff), 15.72 Wed (–0.8%); VIX/VIX3M ratio approx.0.80–0.82 — contango held throughout, no stress signal despite the Tuesday equity drawdown.^{56,57} Options market is pricing a **approx.7% implied move** for Nvidia into its 26 Aug earnings print, well above its approx.2.8% average realized move over the trailing four quarters.⁵⁸ Dealer positioning reads call-heavy/positive-gamma into Friday's monthly options expiration — one of the year's largest monthly OI concentrations rolls off, a setup commentators are calling a potential "gamma cliff" with historically elevated realized vol in the week that follows.⁵⁹ **CFTC CoT**: no new release in this window — the next report (data as of Tue 18 Aug) is due Fri 21 Aug per the CFTC's own schedule; nothing new to report versus the prior edition's 11 Aug data.⁶⁰ **Funding**: ON RRP negligible throughout (approx.\$0.15–0.32B); SOFR approx.3.65–3.66%; no new Fed H.4.1 in-window, next due Thu 20 Aug afternoon.^{61,62}

6 • The day ahead

Date	Event	Consensus / note
Thu 20 Aug	Walmart FQ2 2027 earnings, approx.7am ET	Adj. EPS \$0.74, revenue approx.\$186.8B (LSEG) ⁶³
Thu 20 Aug	Deere & Co. earnings, before open	EPS \$4.70 on \$10.73B revenue ⁶³
Thu 20 Aug	Advance Auto Parts earnings	EPS \$0.81 on \$2.04B revenue ⁶³
Thu 20 Aug	Initial jobless claims, 8:30am ET	Consensus 214K vs prior 209K ⁶⁴
Thu 20 Aug	Fed H.4.1 balance sheet, approx.4:30pm ET	First release since 13 Aug
Fri 21 Aug	S&P Global flash PMIs (Aug)	July baseline: Services 56.0, Manufacturing 49.5 (contraction) ⁶⁵
Fri 21 Aug	Monthly equity options expiration	Large OI roll-off; positive-gamma unwind risk (Section 5)
Fri 21 Aug	CFTC Commitment of Traders, 3:30pm ET	Data as of Tue 18 Aug

After-hours into Thursday: Nordson beat and raised FY guidance (+7.2% AH); Coty mixed, revenue beat but a narrow per-share loss (–6.6%).⁶⁶ Confirmed Asia-session levels and US futures for Thursday's open were not obtainable at research cutoff (Annex A) — Walmart's release itself post-dates this edition's window.

Annex A — Could not be verified this edition

Sector/breadth: closing 11-sector GICS table unobtainable for all three sessions; Wednesday sector-level closing breadth not located (only qualitative "healthcare/cyclicals led, tech lagged" color).

Silver, Wed 19 Aug: three sources disagreed on both magnitude and direction (−2.85% to +1.26%); reported as a \$63–66/oz range rather than a single print.

WTI, Investing.com print: one aggregator showed WTI −0.21% to \$83.88 Wed versus the settlement-sourced \$85.83 (+1.1%) used in this edition; treated as likely mis-scraped/misdated and not used.

USD/MXN, Wed 19 Aug: two same-outlet articles disagreed (16.96 vs 17.07) with contradictory precious-metals framing embedded in each; not reported as a single figure.

Copper, Mon/Tue prints: identical \$6.6040/lb figures appeared under both dates in different articles, suggesting a stale republish; both confirm the 12 Aug \$6.7140 record was not broken, which is the load-bearing fact carried forward.

Annex B — Sources

[1] AP, "How major US stock indexes fared Monday 8/17/2026," Yakima Herald / WaPo syndication

[2] AP, "How major US stock indexes fared Tuesday 8/18/2026," Mankato Free Press

[3] AP, "How major US stock indexes fared Wednesday 8/19/2026," WTOP; cross-checked Yahoo Finance market wrap

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[6] stockinvest.us, "Micron stock price fell more than -7.02% Tuesday," 18 Aug 2026

[7] TradingKey, "Market Movers: AVGO," 18 Aug 2026

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[10] Federal Reserve, "Minutes of the FOMC, July 28–29, 2026," *federalreserve.gov* press release, 19 Aug 2026

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[15] CNBC, "Odds the Fed will hike in September tumble following big July jobs miss," 7 Aug 2026

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[18] Motley Fool, "Why TJX Stock Dropped Today," 19 Aug 2026; Investing.com, "TJX stock drops as profit outlook falls short"

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[20] StockStory, "Estee Lauder Beats Q2 Sales Expectations," 19 Aug 2026

[21] StockAnalysis.com, Lowe's (LOW) historical price data, 19 Aug 2026 close

[22] MarketBeat, "LOW Price History," 19 Aug 2026 close

[23] Reuters via Yahoo Finance / CNBC, "Oil edges up on uncertainty over exports through Hormuz," 19 Aug 2026, 3:12pm ET (settlement report)

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[25] Yahoo Finance, "Stock Market Today (Aug. 19, 2026): S&P 500 rises despite tech weakness," 19 Aug 2026

[26] TMGM, "Forex Today: US Dollar sags to two-month lows," 17 Aug 2026

[27] CNBC, "L3Harris ousts CEO Chris Kubasik over unspecified 'conduct,' stock drops 4%," 17 Aug 2026

[28] Investing.com, "L3Harris CEO steps down amid conduct review," 17 Aug 2026

[29] Fortune, "Ousted L3Harris CEO Chris Kubasik forfeits \$45 million," 17 Aug 2026

[30] CNBC, "Berkshire adds \$17 billion to Alphabet stake," 15 Aug 2026

[31] Benzinga, "Berkshire Hathaway Doubles Down on Homebuilders, Makes Alphabet Top Holding," 15 Aug 2026

[32] Detroit News/Reuters syndication, "Tech stocks weigh on Wall Street as Iran stalemate lifts oil, yields," 18 Aug 2026 (headline/URL only, full text blocked)

[33] Benzinga, "Leading And Lagging Sectors For August 17, 2026" and "...August 18, 2026"

[34] Bloomberg, "Moderna's 160% Surge Burns Shorts in Painful \$5 Billion Loss," 19 Aug 2026 (headline)

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[37] BNN Bloomberg, "Canada's CPI rose to 3% in July year-over-year," 17 Aug 2026

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[42] Al Jazeera, "Iran prepares to keep economy alive as US threatens further sanctions," 18 Aug 2026

VVIX, MOVE index, CBOE daily put/call ratio, dealer GEX/gamma numeric levels: no dated third-party numeric readout located this window.

VIX9D / VIX6M numeric closes: Yahoo endpoints blocked, CBOE dashboard shell-only, as in prior editions.

Named AVGO/AMAT options-flow or gamma commentary: no session-dated, attributable readout found for this window (generic screener pages excluded).

Thursday 20 Aug pre-open Asia levels and confirmed US equity futures: not obtainable at research cutoff (approx.05:30 ET); one premarket piece asserted "futures trading higher" without independent corroboration.

Official CME FedWatch probabilities and official Treasury par yields for same-day sessions: pages not directly fetchable; secondary-source ranges used and disclosed throughout.

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Method note: Every figure in this edition carries a named, dated source; where sources disagreed beyond rounding, both figures are disclosed and the more authoritative (settlement-language, post-close-timestamped, or primary-release) source is used, per standing house rules. This edition's window (three trading sessions, Mon 17–Wed 19 Aug) is wider than the normal one-session cadence because no briefing ran on Tue 18 or Wed 19 Aug; Monday and Tuesday accordingly received condensed, catch-up-depth treatment rather than the full single-session depth normally applied. Items that could not be sourced to the required standard are listed in Annex A rather than estimated.